

Eight Years, No Winner

Lesson 30 — The Iran-Iraq War, 1980–1988

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain Saddam Hussein's specific motives for invading Iran in 1980

2

Trace the war's three phases, from invasion to stalemate to Iraq's final offensives

3

Describe the international response to Iraq's chemical weapons use

4

Evaluate the war's real consequences, given that no territory changed hands

A revolution, and a neighbour who saw an opportunity

Lessons 22–27 covered Iran's revolution in depth. This lesson turns to how that revolution's neighbour, Saddam Hussein's Iraq, reacted — launching the twentieth century's longest conventional war between two states.

The Shatt al-Arab and the Algiers Accord

A 1975 agreement had settled the Iran-Iraq border along the middle of the Shatt al-Arab waterway, Iraq's only outlet to the Gulf, in exchange for Iran ending support for Kurdish rebels in northern Iraq. Saddam had signed under duress, while Iran held clear military superiority, and never accepted the terms as final.

A neighbour Saddam judged newly vulnerable

The 1979 revolution had purged the Shah's experienced officer corps and cancelled Iran's Western arms contracts, while Khomeini's calls to export Islamic revolution directly threatened Iraq's own Sunni-led, Shia-majority state. Saddam calculated Iran was militarily weakened and hoped an invasion of oil-rich Khuzestan would trigger an Arab uprising against Tehran.

Invasion, then stall

Iraq invaded on 22 September 1980, advancing into Khuzestan — but the expected Arab uprising never materialised; the region's Arabic-speaking minority remained loyal to Iran. By December 1980, Iraq's advance had stalled entirely.

Iran counterattacks, then keeps going

Iranian forces recaptured lost territory by June 1982, including the city of Khorramshahr after twenty-five days of brutal fighting. Facing a genuine choice, Khomeini rejected Saddam's ceasefire offer, choosing instead to invade Iraq itself in pursuit of a far larger goal: overthrowing Saddam's regime entirely.

Trench warfare, city bombing, and the Tanker War

Iran's offensives from 1982 onward gained little further ground against determined Iraqi defence. Both sides bombed each other's cities directly; from 1984, naval forces on both sides attacked neutral oil tankers in the Gulf, aiming to strangle each other's oil revenue — a war fought as much through economic pressure as territory.

Chemical weapons, and a muted response

Iraq made extensive use of chemical weapons against Iranian forces — confirmed by UN investigation in March 1986 — and later against its own Kurdish population in the 1988 Anfal campaign, killing an estimated 50,000 to 100,000 people. No serious international sanctions followed; the United States, eager to see Iran contained, blocked stronger action at the UN Security Council.

Exhaustion, and a reluctant ceasefire

Iraq's 1988 offensives recaptured the Faw Peninsula and pushed Iranian forces back, just as Iran's economy collapsed under the war's strain and American naval forces increasingly clashed with Iranian vessels in the Gulf. Facing potential defeat on two fronts, Khomeini accepted UN Resolution 598's ceasefire terms in August 1988 — terms Iraq had already accepted a year earlier.

A war with almost no territorial change

~500,000+

Estimated deaths on both sides combined

8 years

Duration — the longest conventional war of the 20th century

0

Significant permanent territorial change to either country's borders

Iraq alone borrowed over \$40 billion from Gulf states like Saudi Arabia and Kuwait to fund the war effort — debt that would shape its next major decision.

Two entrenched regimes, and a debt that would not disappear

The war strengthened both Saddam's authoritarian rule and Khomeini's clerical state, each having survived an existential threat. Iraq's massive war debt to Gulf neighbours, however, created a financial pressure Saddam could not easily escape — a pressure that would shape his next major decision, covered in our next lesson.

A full essay attempt

'Khomeini's decision to invade Iraq in 1982, rather than accept Saddam's ceasefire offer, needlessly prolonged a war Iran had already effectively won.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence about the 1982 ceasefire offer and its rejection
- Address the counter-argument that overthrowing Saddam was a legitimate strategic goal

Key terms from today

Shatt al-Arab

The contested waterway at the centre of the border dispute.

Anfal campaign

Iraq's 1988 chemical weapons campaign against its own Kurdish population.

Tanker War

Mutual attacks on Gulf oil shipping from 1984 onward.

UN Resolution 598

The 1987 ceasefire terms Iraq accepted immediately, Iran only in 1988.

What to remember

Saddam's 1980 invasion, launched against a neighbour he judged newly vulnerable after revolution, produced eight years of brutal, largely static warfare, extensive chemical weapons use met with muted international response, and roughly half a million deaths — while leaving both regimes more entrenched, and Iraq burdened with a debt that would shape its next major decision.

Lesson 31 — The Gulf War, 1990–91

Next lesson: how Iraq's war debt and ambitions turned toward Kuwait — and the international coalition that reversed the invasion within weeks.